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Tommy Newsom & Ross Tompkins

Saxophonist Tommy Newsom was born in Portsmouth, Virginia in 1929. his musical education was first in the classical field as a clarinetist. After his studies at Peabody he was able to employ his saxophone and arranging skills with the Air Force Band and later in the studios of New York City. He toured with Benny Goodman and worked in a swing sextet with Ruby Braff and Marshall Brown. In 1962 Tommy joined the NBC music staff and became lead alto for the Tonight Show Band. He eventually became Assistant Conductor to Doc Severinsen and moved to Los Angeles with the show, where he became known for his dry wit as well as his musical skills.

Ross Tompkins is a Detroit native who studied piano at the New England Conservatory. From 1960-67 he freelanced in New York, performing with Clark Terry, Kai Winding, Herb Ellis and other major artists. He joined his friend Tommy Newsom in the Tonight Show Band and held down the piano chair for the duration, also performing with the Louis Bellson Big Band in Los Angeles. He records frequently as a sideman and as a solo pianist.

Tommy and Ross can be found performing at festivals and jazz parties across the country. They were interviewed in Los Angeles by Monk Rowe on September 3, 1995.

MR: Good afternoon. We are filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. My name is Monk Rowe, and it's a great pleasure today to have two guests who are fixtures in the jazz scene, especially on the west coast here. Can I call you guys "fixtures?"

RT: Well certainly.

MR: Saxophonist and arranger Tommy Newsom and keyboardist Ross Tompkins. Welcome, gentlemen.

TN: Thank you.

MR: We've been fortunate to listen to the music you've been creating before we talk today so I kind of have a starting place. The group you're working with right now, the fellows that you've been with for quite a while thanks to the Tonight Show, and you can really tell in the music. I was interested last night in that when you each did your solo spot that you picked something very, kind of gentle and slow tempo.

RT: I know I did. Well there's a level of activity around a jazz festival that tends to be on the frenetic side sometimes.

MR: Yeah. Especially with all the Dixieland going on too.

RT: Yeah, that's true.

MR: It seems to be very —

RT: And it just seems to be a relief sometimes to just calm down for a moment. That's what I think anyway. And Tommy played "Skylark" too which is a—

TN: Yeah, I played a slow one too, and I guess many of us did. But what we try to do is alternate so we don't get too many of the same thing in a row.

MR: It was a nice paced set and it was nice to hear "Skylark" which isn't something that someone always does. And you were playing "True Love?"

RT: Yes I was. [inaudible] medley and went into three quarter time.

MR: I think you found the lost chord too.

TN: He sure did.

MR: I mean one thing about jazz piano is the kind of instant harmonization, what can you do with that, and that was some really interesting things there.

RT: Well, if you enjoyed it, I'm happy.

MR: I loved it. And you seem to favor the middle of the keyboard a great deal, and I kept waiting for you to finally get up there, and when you did it was such a nice, really a nice release kind of I guess.

RT: Well I'm a lazy guy. And I'm disinclined to reach too far in either direction.

MR: Maybe get the bench to move or something. Yeah. Well that was really enjoyable. And can I take you guys back a little bit to why this kind of music? Why did you get into jazz and swing music?

TN: That's really hard to say. I grew up in, I was born in 1929. So I grew up during the big band era, and like pop music was, a lot of it was standards. Like you know the Gershwin tunes and Cole Porter and Jerome Kern and all that. And a lot of it was "The Three Little Fishes."

RT: Well Mel Powell says he grew up when popular music was good and good music was popular.

TN: Sure that's about right.

RT: Not so with kids these days.

TN: But jazz was part of the music. Jazz was part of the way the bands approached things. They were jazzed up and they were all influenced by jazz and I came in that way. I heard it and it attracted me and I loved the improvising and oddly enough I think people know when a soloist is making it, even if they have no idea what's going on. There's something that happens I guess, because look at all these people that show up at these festivals. I don't think they have much of a clue, other than something strikes them. You know they don't know the chords or anything that's happening. They might know the tunes. But they know when it's happening. And I think as a little kid I did too. You did too, didn't you, Ross?

RT: Yeah, I listened to the radio. We had no television set until 1949 or 50. Before that we were listening to the radio all the time. And in Detroit, they had, well actually the station was over across in Windsor, CKLW in Windsor, they played Fats Waller records all the time. That's how I—

TN: Canadian station, yeah, I see.

MR: Was there a point where, did you both have some quote classical training? You went to a Conservatory, right?

RT: I did. I went to college for one year. Tommy went for the whole—

TN: Yeah, I had four years at Peabody Institute/Conservatory. Yeah but you were schooled, I mean your piano technique sounds to me like you played all that stuff.

RT: Yeah, I could play the, what do you call it, the repertoire I guess, the best I could at that age. I stopped when I was in my teens and started just playing jazz all the time, after I was about 14 or 15. But I started until then. First it was my grandmother and then my father and then they sent me to a real guy. And he was able to teach me to teach myself fortunately, because he died when I was maybe 15 or 16 years old when he died. But he had showed me how to teach myself, which I find to be a valuable thing.

TN: Well I think people do that mainly. I was self taught to start with and then the like formal training, in fact all of the things I did like writing and all that, I just learned by trial and error. But what the professional assistance kind of cleans things up for you and confirms some things that you kind of figured out for yourself.

MR: Right. You anticipated my question and that was when the arranging bug started for you. Was that something that you were interested in from an early age?

TN: Yeah, I think so, yeah. I used to deliver papers and I'd be kind of imagining an orchestration going on.

RT: Yeah, now see I did the same thing but keyboard stuff. Really.

TN: I think you do stuff like that. It's like, what is it, unforced practice. I had a long bus ride to school. And I had had a teacher that did me the good favor of making me write out all the scales and you know the three minors and the major scales, in all keys. And I would kind of go over them in my mind, or make up combinations, you know like thirds, up and down thirds.

RT: You know yeah, the harmonic minor and different kinds of —

TN: Yeah.

RT: Yeah I had to learn all that too. And if I had to do it right now, I wouldn't — it's been so long ago.

TN: Oh I'll bet it would come right back to you.

MR: To say them?

TN: But you know what it does, it did for me anyhow, to write those things out then when I went to play them it was ten times easier. Because I wasn't fishing for the note.

MR: Right.

TN: I wasn't even having to read them hardly because boy it stuck in my mind.

MR: Was saxophone your first instrument?

TN: It was, yeah. Yeah, it was. I lusted after the saxophone, I really did. It was grand thing.

RT: Well after you got over to — did you go to Peabody before you were in the Air Force or after?

TN: Well let me think. It was before, yeah.

RT: You were in the Air Force first, and then went to—

TN: No I went to Peabody and then the Air Force.

RT: Because he was in the Airmen of Note, the Air Force Band, which is still going.

TN: Yeah. Better than ever.

MR: And Peabody had saxophone?

TN: No, saxophone was not accepted.

MR: I kind of wondered.

RT: The clarinet he had to play.

TN: I had to study clarinet and they did me a big favor by making me do that.

MR: Yeah, because that's a hard instrument to learn the other way after you do the saxophone it seems like.

TN: Yeah, well saxophone comes easy see? I mean you know it's just up and down. Like Ernie Watts says, "The notes go up, the notes go down."

RT: It's just like a piano. One is right next to the other one.

TN: Yeah and you push the key and it's the octave higher. With the clarinet you push the key, it's a twelfth higher.

RT: It goes an octave and a—

TN: And a fifth. Very confusing.

RT: Oh so if you're playing C on a clarinet and you push the octave key, you're going to get G then right?

TN: Yeah.

MR: Yeah. And when you're used to the saxophone, see, that's.

RT: I'm getting educated on reeds and woodwinds right here.

TN: That's why clarinet players are crazy.

MR: Why are you playing that when you could play a sax? I don't understand. What was your first like memorable playing experience, either big band or combo or what you would consider to be your real start. I know you did Kai Winding.

RT: Yeah, I was with his group early, I was in my late teens. I think I was 19 years old and I was working with Kai Winding. And some other friends of ours, Johnny Mesa and Carl Fontana.

TN: Oh, yeah, that was a nice group. Four trombones and rhythm. Great.

RT: And I'd been briefly with Benny Goodman's big band when I was even younger than that I think, maybe 18-1/2. And then later I played with his small group, the sextet. The trumpet player was Doc Cheatham, who is now ninety-some years old and still playing.

MR: Yeah, we were fortunate enough to talk with him.

TN: Did you? Oh you talked to Doc?

RT: I know he's got plenty of stories.

MR: It was just marvelous.

RT: I'm not positive about his age. I think he's maybe 92? Something like that?

MR: Uh, yeah. 91 or 92. And he talked about that particular band and how he had to kind of go back to school a little bit because he had been playing lead, and doing a lot of Latin —

RT: Yeah I knew he did a lot of Latin work.

MR: You know in a small group, having to solo quite a bit, an adjustment.

TN: Interesting.

MR: Did you like working with Goodman? I mean I have to ask you.

TN: I did. It was, you know you had some bizarre moments with him, but you know that was like playing with one of my childhood heroes. He was a giant. And some of the players, you know it was like major league baseball. So I thought it was wonderful. And every once in a while something strange would happen, but the plusses outweighed the minuses.

RT: I think you were safer with Benny in a big band. The more people around, he couldn't, it was harder to single somebody out. But in Las Vegas, he didn't like the drummer. who'd been playing with him for years, Morey Feld, who is a perfectly good drummer. And he sent for Mousy Alexander from New York to come all the way to Las Vegas for the last, well, three weeks altogether, Mousy came and played the last two weeks and Morey Feld had to sit there in a tuxedo every night.

TN: To get paid.

RT: He says if you leave you're not getting paid. So that's the kind of tricks.

TN: Well Benny was very weird with drummers. I don't think he liked any drummers after Gene Krupa. And he didn't like Gene Krupa.

MR: Ed told us a story, maybe he'll tell you if you ask him about it, how he handled Benny. And it was pretty good. I don't know if I should go through it now but—

RT: Ed Shaughnessy you mean?

MR: Yeah.

TN: Oh, he made him put the money on the drummer.

MR: Oh, he said he just got — Lionel Hampton said if you have any trouble with Benny, just get weirder than he is. And he did that, and I guess it worked for him at the time. Anyway, everybody's got Benny stories. So you guys were kind of through the years have been alternating between big bands and combos and some studio work.

RT: Yeah, I always play even, well Tommy was with the Tonight Show before I was. He was there with Skitch Henderson and Milton DeLugg. I started when Doc Severinsen started in 1967. But I always went right from there down and played someplace else. If it wasn't the Half Note it was the Roosevelt Grill or something or the Plaza Nine. There was always some clubs.

TN: Yeah, I asked Ross one day, you know because you spend your whole life working in gin mills and things, you know, low paying jobs, but the jazz scene is usually not high paying generally. And I asked him why he continued to work like down at the Half Note, down in the Village during the Tonight Show. Because you know you work all those years and you've got a nice paying job more or less, and he continued to work down there. And I think he explained it this way, he says, "I work at NBC to get cab fare to get down to the village."

RT: Oh, yeah, I forgot about that. Thank you. One of my better remarks.

MR: It must have been in your blood, right? You couldn't stop doing it. Well that's great.

TN: Well you know he was dedicated to playing. That's what he really wanted to do. And I really did too but I didn't have guts enough to — I got sidetracked with the writing and I had a lot of hats on.

RT: Well once in a while you'd come and sit in with us at Eddie Condon's. I remember that.

TN: Yeah, no I used to do that.

RT: See he was already with the Tonight Show. I wasn't yet. In about 1965 I was working at Eddie Condon's. I had a very good group. It was myself, no bass player, Cliff Leeman was the drummer, Cutty Cutshall, great trombone player, Peanuts Hucko on clarinet and either Buck Clayton or Yank Lawson on trumpet. So that was good. And Tommy used to come and sit in with us once in a while.

MR: You must have had to develop a pretty good left hand thing if you were working without a bass player?

RT: Yeah. Every other place in New York had a bass player except Condon's — no bass.

MR: Is that because the ceiling is too low? I heard some clubs in New York, I don't know—

TN: Yeah that's strange why they did that.

MR: When you would write a chart for the Tonight Show, how did that come about? Were you asked to write a chart? Did you say, "I want to write a chart" and then talk to the powers that be?

TN: It started, I submitted a couple. I wrote a couple of things, just 'cause I wanted to do it. And I wanted to see if they would hire me doing that. And they liked them enough to play them and sometimes you get in some interesting, I got in an interesting bind between a band leader and Benny. And both of them thought the other one should pay.

RT: Oh yeah? I don't know this story.

TN: It was an arrangement of "The Preacher." Do you remember that a long time ago?

RT: The tune with Horace Silver?

TN: Yeah. There was one with clarinet that was for Benny for that show.

RT: Yeah.

TN: And the band leader—

RT: Who was this Skitch now?

TN: Yeah. Said Benny was to pay and Benny said he was. So I just ate that one.

RT: And you know Benny Goodman's not going to pay.

MR: Yeah I was going to say, he wasn't going to lose on that deal, right?

TN: So that ended up being one of those things that about forty-five people Xeroxed and I never, just never got paid.

MR: Does it ever get frustrating? Some of your music, the T.V. audience must have heard the first ten seconds and the last five seconds, you know? That always bugged me.

TN: Oh, yeah.

MR: The band would start out and it sounds so great—

RT: Well if you were in the studio, you heard a lot of music. You can tell it by how many commercials, because we played through all the commercials. Unfortunately, out over the air it only came the last ten or fifteen seconds.

TN: Yeah. In fact, you know what happened?

RT: We used to be on the air for a minute at midnight every night, and then they took that away and filled that up with commercials.

TN: Yeah. We played a gig at Donte's in L.A. one time. It was a jazz joint. And it was the whole Tonight Show band and I was in front. And we were playing the same arrangements, but when we were playing the jobs we'd get to the third page, which we never had got to that.

RT: Some guys never saw that page.

TN: That's where it disintegrated. I don't know whether it was that they couldn't read, or I think it was the shock of the thing, you know?

MR: That's funny. That's funny. You expect someone to say "okay, cut."

TN: That's right. Nobody to save you.

MR: I know you've had some interesting recording experiences. You've made quite a few. In fact I have to ask you about one of your CDs here.

RT: Oh, which one?

MR: You look a little bit different here.

RT: Well let's see, that's from 1993 or 92.

MR: "The Phantom."

RT: Oh, yes, that's a nickname from many years ago.

MR: Yeah? You want to tell us about it?

RT: Zoot Sims, my friend Zoot Sims, he says "Ross can disappear in a phone booth." Said "it's amazing."

MR: "The Phantom." And it re-surfaced after all this time.

RT: Yeah. The gentleman that's involved with that label, Progressive Records, Gus Statiras, who is a man with the thousands of records down in the lobby? He knew about that. He was around. There was a letter that came to me and it had my first name and then quotation marks The Phantom and then my last name, in care of the Half Note as a matter of fact, which was immediately put up like bulletin board style. And within a week, the jazz community in New York City in the 60s was very compact. Everybody knew everybody else. And within a week I was "The Phantom."

MR: The nicknames seem to just hang on so, we have a book I've been reading and it has a whole chapter just about nicknames. They seem to stick really quick. Did you ever have one? You know I think, personally, that you were a comedian in another life.

RT: He's funny.

TN: What was the question?

MR: See?

RT: Right into his act.

MR: It wasn't a question, it was a strange personal observation but you said on the elevator coming up, "timing is everything." And last night, he comes up, "Here's a tune called 'Clear the Room.'"

TN: People were leaving.

MR: Yeah. The timing.

RT: We usually clear them out much faster than that. Well anyway, you were asking about Bill Basie and Joe Williams? Which I've known Joe Williams so long that I don't remember where I met him. I can't pin it down. I was trying to think, I knew of course a couple of days ago I would be talking to you and I was trying to think well where did you meet Joe Williams. It's been so long ago. He was just there all of a sudden.

MR: He was a Chicago guy, I don't know—

TN: Did you know him before Basie?

RT: No.

TN: No, I didn't either.

RT: No.

TN: In fact that's where I first saw him was with Count Basie and then I met him later when we worked with him on the show.

RT: I knew a lot of guys in Basie's band. I knew Snooky and Frank Foster and Frank Wess and Charlie Fowlkes and Joe Newman and Freddie Green and Eddie Jones. Like the 60s.

TN: Yeah. It was that nice thing.

RT: Because Zoot and I used to argue. I was very fond of that band, of that period when Snooky was playing lead, you know, Sonny Payne, Eddie Jones. And Zoot and I used to argue whether the '38 band with Sweets and Buck and all those guys, which one was better. And they were both great. I think probably the one from the 60s might be a little rehearsed a little more or something.

TN: Yeah, but the earlier band was like an original.

RT: They both — you could make a case for either one of them certainly.

MR: Wasn't the earlier band playing more head arrangements?

RT: They had a lot of head arrangements, yeah. "Jumpin' at the Woodside" at first it wasn't even written out I heard.

TN: Yeah. Oddly enough, I don't think only that, I had a long conversation with Teddy Wilson one night, flying across the Atlantic believe it or not. And he was telling me about the old Fletcher Henderson band. This is slightly off the subject. But he went down this list of tunes, we got to talking about head arrangements. And all those things, like "King Porter Stomp" and "Big John Special"—

RT: I remember "Big John Special." "King Porter Stomp" is pretty complicated to be a head arrangement.

TN: But it was. It just developed over time.

RT: You know, the bass line and everything, how that goes.

TN: Yeah. Well I mean there were parts—

RT: They refined it later.

TN: But he said all those great old things that have come up, were things that guys in the band made up — "Sing Sing Sing" of Benny Goodman's was mainly head I was told. Some of it was written out but they added things. And then I later talked to Neal Hefti a lot about the great Woody Herman band that made "Apple Honey" and "Caledonia" and all those things. And those things were head arrangements.

RT: Neal came and played his trumpet with me last Sunday night.

TN: Did he really?

RT: It was the first time in 30 years. He got his trumpet, he went to Uan Rasey for a week, and he came and sat in with Jack Sheldon and myself at the Money Tree last Sunday

night. He said, “This is the first time I’ve played in 30 years.” He got himself a brand new beautiful trumpet.

TN: Good for him.

RT: And he wrote down, these are five songs I can play: “Might as Well be Spring,” “L’il Darlin’” but he had a great time.

MR: Was the Basie group a standard for your guys to listen to? I mean was it—

RT: Well for swinging, yeah. I mean Duke’s band was another think, the Duke for harmony I guess.

TN: Yeah, and creativity.

RT: But for out and out swing.

TN: That and the Jimmie Lunceford band was an awful good swinging band.

MR: Those are two names that keep coming up.

TN: The best I would say. That and Basie.

RT: Have you talked to Snooky or do you plan to?

MR: Yeah. We had a nice conversation.

RT: Yeah. Because he was with Lunceford and Basie. That’s a lot of history there.

TN: Yeah, well they were just special. A special time and a bunch of special people came together I think.

MR: Now Joe Williams did a few appearances on the Tonight Show.

RT: Oh, how many? I don’t know, a hundred?

TN: Oh, Lord, yeah. Carson loved him, yeah. And the audience did too. And I mean even when he wasn’t scheduled, if somebody’d fall out, you know one of the guests would not appear or something—

RT: They’d call Joe.

TN: Joe was living in Vegas, he’d just come in, and half the time he’d sing a blues and we’d make up some riffs.

RT: The two easiest people over the years that Doc Severinsen and I used to like to see, and this is going to sound ridiculous, were Ethel Merman and Joe Williams. They only did one take and heard the full run of it. They’d run it through once, that’s it. And that’s the only two people.

TN: Did I tell you about what Dick Perry told me about Ethel Merman? I had to conduct for her one night. She had this great long medley. I mean a medley of everything she’d ever done kind of you know, from stem to stern? And I was frettin’ about it, to remember tempos. And Dick Perry said, he was one of the trumpet players—

RT: He was one of the trumpet players in the Tonight Show band in New York, was Dick Perry.

TN: Yeah. And he'd worked in the pit behind her on Broadway. He says, "Don't worry." He says, "when Ethel starts you go, and when she stops it's over."

MR: Isn't that nice to be in that position? Oh. I have one personal memory of the Tonight Show that I had to ask about. I think it was Cloris Leachman, and she thought she could sing or something.

TN: Yes. I remember her singing.

MR: And I remember the piano player, and it was probably you trying to help her find her note and it was like Ding [sings].

RT: It was a beautiful song.

MR: And she couldn't get started. I felt so— and I'm thinking of you. Like how unsubtle are you going to get here. You know DING—

RT: You help them out any way you can.

TN: Well sad to say all actors think they can sing. Not many can.

MR: What was it like moving from New York to L.A.? Were you glad that happened at the time?

RT: I like them both as long as it's one or the other. But it was easy. They, when we used to come out to visit before we moved here, we'd come out for two or three weeks a couple of times a year. And this was before the Sheraton Universal Hotel was even built. So we used to have to stay way down in Hollywood at what is now the Hyatt on Sunset. In those days it was called Gene Autrey's Continental Hotel, and we had to drive. Now that's in the late 60s. About 70, the Sheraton Universal got built so we'd stay there, it was a mile from Burbank. And in return for our staying there, they would plug them on the Tonight Show every night. Carson called it the "Sheraton Unusual Hotel." So when we moved out from New York they gave us, nobody knew where they were going to live yet or anything, so they just gave us a month and said, "Here, you've got the hotel for a month." So that made it — it simplified things.

MR: What's it like today doing, you're still doing studio work and has that changed over the years with how studios have changed and electronics and all that. Has that affected your business?

TN: Oh, Lord, in the greatest way. When I started doing some studio work in New York the first year I was there, I got more work from fallout, I mean from referrals, because they would get through all the busy guys. I got more work then the last year I was in New York. Either that or they had all heard me and there was no more calls. But I prefer to think of the other.

RT: The man is modest.

TN: Well what I'm trying to say is see at that time there was no, hardly no, the electronic things were like guitars and a Leslie organ or something. But they would have five saxes.

You could get your feet wet, you know you could get used to being in the studio with the red light on because if you started, if you'd go there like as the only sax, I've had that happen too. It's a terrible feeling if you're not used to it. Because all your perceptions change. If you — I got that kind of mind where things bother me.

RT: There was some fine record dates. Do you remember the "Marijuana Reeds" with Zoot Sims and Gene Quill.

MR: The Marijuana Reeds?

RT: Yeah, so instead of the Tijuana Brass they called them the Marijuana Reeds.

TN: A group that Al Cohn named, it was Gene Quill and Phil Woods, he called them Leopold and Loeb.

RT: People will have to work that out.

MR: But finish your thought.

TN: Well starting out, I mean years ago, there was a lot of work and they used a lot of people. It was like a large amount of work and a large workforce. And in L.A. too. In fact, New York was busier than L.A. at the time I'm talking about, in the late 50s. And then when the machines came in, like synthesizers, and improvement in tape techniques, you know where they could overdub things and sel-sync things, you know? Well you'd make strings sound like twice as many people while they're playing. All of that diminished the demand. And it's sad to say it's dwindling down. And New York is mainly Broadway now.

MR: Yeah, and even the Broadway, I'm not sure how it is there, but when we see some of the shows that come up in Central, New York, the pit bands are six and seven people. And they always have two or three people on a keyboard.

TN: The keyboards are doing it.

MR: And you're hearing all these things that are—

RT: Yeah, I don't know in the city I doubt they're doing that but I don't know. Who do I know that does that. I know Bill Crow and Joe Wilder, they're still Broadway.

TN: Are they? Yeah I guess Joe is. Because it pays very well, but people get nuts in there. You know you play the same note at the same place, the same second, every night. I used to do subs in the show and they're all reading newspapers. I leaned over one day, it's like a romantic scene or something and I was subbing on bass sax, which—

MR: Bass sax. Did you have to borrow one?

TN: With bass sax there's no doubt when you're playing, I'll tell you that. So they're all reading the newspaper, the conductor is reading the newspaper and everything, and the people are acting up there, and nobody cares you know. And I leaned forward to just blow a little warm air in there, because it was a cue coming up, to keep the reed wet, and went bruuuch— It was like a cannon had gone off. And another highlight.

RT: That reminds me of the drummer in England, it's a famous story, with the gong, the guy, he's drunk and he's in the pit in a Broadway show, but in London you know he rouses out of a stupor and hits this giant gong, you know, right in the wrong place. And he looks around and everybody's just in shock. So he didn't know what to do, he says, "Dinner is served." That's a famous tale. Everybody knows that one.

MR: What's it like at these festivals? Getting thrown in so many different situations and playing?

RT: Well it's good for you. You never know. Now today I'm just playing all solo piano so it's a whole different story, which I wasn't too ready for that at 1:30 in the afternoon. I'm not good. I do better after the sun goes down, personally. Some guys can do it, they get up at 10:00 in the morning, but it's not my thing. Children of the night — I guess I belong to that group.

MR: What's in the future for you guys? Any recording projects coming up?

TN: Right now I seem to be becalmed actually.

RT: Well I saw you, we worked at South Carolina Jazz Festival a couple of months ago down in Columbia. And we had a little party for Clark Terry, his 75th birthday. So that was fun.

TN: Oh, yeah, we'll be doing some jazz festivals and things like that. Recording comes and goes. I just did some things for Louis Bellson, who maintains a big band sometimes. And the trick is to get somebody to pay for a date for a big band. So that was different, you know it was fun to do and all that.

MR: Did you do something with Jane Jarvis fairly recently?

TN: I made an album with her several years ago, with Monty Budwig and Jake Hanna. That was fun. And we did it in a little small studio. Yeah I'd forgotten about that, that was nice. Those things come and go, it's hard to predict. I had forgotten about, from being steadily employed all those years, you know. But now you can't predict what's happening. I mean there's things coming up, I've got something in Phoenix next year and something with Jane Jarvis in Tampa this year in November. But somehow it fills itself in, doesn't it? I mean I couldn't really say what's happening except on certain long term things.

RT: Yeah, I was looking the other day, because we worked every day for so long it was funny not to show up someplace every day, until you get used to it. And I'm looking, the only way I can keep track is the American Express book calendar they send you once a year and you can write down where you're supposed to be. And as I looked through my book it's slowly getting busier and busier. It's slow but—

TN: You see working steady is a two-edged sword. Because they say don't bother, call somebody else because he's busy.

MR: Word gets out that you can't do it.

TN: It happens, yeah. But the nice part is that you know where your next meal's coming from, too.

RT: Well the only recording I really do now is just my own, or like some friend of mine tells me to call Tommy, call him, of course I'll do that. We did two or three albums that Tommy wrote, called the T.V. All-Stars or something like that.

TN: Yes, it was an unassuming title, you know, "T.V. All-Stars."

MR: Well they'd already used the World's Greatest Jazz Band, so—

RT: And then we also did, for these same people, a Christmas album that was kind of interesting. There was five different singers — Vic Damone, Jack Jones, Joe Williams, Diane Carroll and Patti Page.

TN: What a memory he's got.

RT: Well I saw it in my drawer the other day. Annie was cleaning out the drawer the other day and that record was in there.

TN: Yeah that sold a lot of records I think. We did that one with mirrors kind of. Because we had a rhythm section on every date, and then one date we used a string quartet, one day we used three French horns, one we used three trombones and a horn, and one of them we had a trumpet, trombone, sax. So what happens if you play them and you mix them all around, you can't tell how many pieces is in there. You know what I mean?

RT: It's all different ensembles.

TN: Every track has a different combination on it. Alternating. It's kind of like a shell game.

MR: And the music becomes in the hands of some producer and you hope they do well with it.

TN: Yeah. Well, it was a kind of a quickie, like two track direct digital, so you can rebalance the tracks but you can't bring anything out, you know what I mean? You can raise a level of a track but that's about it. And you can splice. And that's it. But you can't take mistakes out or put notes in that you wish were there. Like the fancy methods. Those things, they were fun, but you know I don't know how long you could get away with that, trying to make a little group sound big.

MR: Well do you gentlemen have any words of wisdom for our students who might watch this who want to be professional musicians? Besides don't quit your day gig?

RT: Well, there's always a way if you're, if you want it badly enough, you're going to get it. It's probably more difficult now than it was when we were younger.

TN: Yeah, well I think the opportunities —

RT: Who can you go on the road with now? Count Basie is the only band left. And that's not Basie of course it's a ghost band.

TN: Well there's still the Tommy Dorsey band and there's maybe a Woody Herman band.

RT: I think that's part time. I don't think the guy does it all the time or something. But there's not much of a choice. But of course now you can go to almost any college and study jazz,

which there was no such thing as that. He couldn't even bring his saxophone in to Peabody.

TN: Yeah. Actually the college bands are, there's a lot of dynamite college bands, some of the best I've heard.

RT: I guess the most famous one is down there in Texas, that's probably the oldest one.

TN: They'll scare you to death.

RT: The two original students at that school in the 40s were Jimmy Giuffre and Herb Ellis.

TN: Is that right? I didn't know that.

RT: They were the two guys that started off that went to that college.

TN: By golly. Yeah they have a hell of a record. So that, and there are several dynamite service bands.

RT: Yeah, I guess now you either go in the service or you go to college. When we were young you'd go out on the road with some band. That's the first time I saw Tommy Newsom arrangements. I was playing with a territory band down south. I was 16 or 17 years old. Dean Hudson. It was a famous band in its neighborhood. And your friend Johnny Presley was one of the trumpet players, from Virginia. And I'd say, "This is better arrangements than we usually have, where'd you get these?" And he said, "Well my friend, Tommy Newsom." I didn't even know him then.

TN: I didn't know Johnny had that music.

MR: Can you send him a bill or is it too late?

RT: Well he was going to sing so it was like vocal arrangements but there would be an ensemble in the middle. It was better than Hudson's usual stuff.

TN: My own encouragement I could give to people is that things don't stay the same, and the condition that the music business is in right now might change.

RT: It keeps going around, you know.

TN: If acoustic stays out long enough, it might be the new thing in a while, you know, if people get enough of digitally produced sounds, they might—if they hear guys, like hear Snooky Young play. Or Sweets Edison. Did you happen to hear him play?

MR: We talked to him. We didn't get to hear him.

TN: Well he has a way of playing. I don't think a machine could ever do that.

RT: Oh, no, you know who that is, there's no doubt about that. It can't be done electrically. Or Roy Eldridge. Remember I was playing you that tape the other night? You can't duplicate that.

TN: Of course old timers always say that.

MR: But I think it's true.

TN: I do too. And nothing stays the same, so they shouldn't despair.

MR: A lot of folks have been talking about originality and that should be something that you strive for.

TN: Oh, yes. That's the fun of it if you can. One friend of mine, Jimmy Zito, says the fun of jazz is that what you play at that particular time was never be heard before or be heard since. Some of it's been heard before in my case.

RT: I want to tell them that Jimmy Zito was one of our trumpet players in the California Tonight Show band. He was very well known before that, he was with Les Brown for many years. Great guy.

TN: Great player.

RT: That's who Jimmy Zito is.

MR: Okay, great. Well I want to thank you gentlemen for sharing this time with us, with some great insights.

RT: Oh, my pleasure. It's always good to — if you weren't here we'd be sitting here doing this anyway, down in the lounge. But anyway, thanks very much.

MR: On behalf of the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College, I want to thank Tommy Newsom and Ross Tompkins and I hope the rest of your festival goes great, and hope that we'll run into you guys again real soon.

RT: Well thank you. We're going to do the best we can.